

art or in nature, in a painting or a symphony, a ballet or in a single flower, or a horse or a mist-covered mountain.

So how does art relate to hatred, pain and loss? I think it relates simply and directly. An encounter with a work of art transforms us; for a period of time, it takes us out of an unavoidable condition of fear and uncertainty. Art does not stop violence, sickness or war but it takes us to a new place, a totally different time and perspective. Art can change us, turn us around, give us a new sense of freedom where we can breathe in a space that won't last forever but can so deeply refresh us that we are able to re-enter the battle of hatred knowing that the terrible things are not the only reality. God's great creation contains both good and bad, love and hatred, beauty and loss, suffering and joy, so perhaps the first trick of living is to recognise, not deny, the presence of darkness and light through life.

The second trick to living is to negotiate a path between the forces of light and darkness so we don't stumble.

And the third trick teaches us that if we do fall down, as we probably will many times, we should just get up, start over and keep going.

"ART DOES NOT STOP VIOLENCE, SICKNESS OR WAR BUT IT TAKES US TO A NEW PLACE, A TOTALLY DIFFERENT TIME AND PERSPECTIVE."

SHAH RUKH KHAN

So, art plays this crucial role of recharging us, to keep walking on life's uncertain path of hatred. A lot of the hatred we see around the world is linked directly or indirectly to the manifestation of religious viewpoints, misinterpretations, misrepresentations, just plain misreading and misguidance. I got all these on the Internet, the thoughts are of other people but I truly feel them. A gentleman in Japan has said art is the mother of religion because the root word of religion is from the Latin word *religare* which means unifier. Works of art and the beauty in nature are awakeners and stimulators that satisfy the deepest of our

emotions. Religion is the overall connector of all the different pieces of life, sometimes contradictory and sometimes not. All are subjective preferences in one universal peaceful whole. Have you ever made a choice in appreciating a piece of art? Do you like it or dislike it because it was done by a Hindu or a Muslim? When I was young I did not say I am not listening to Michael Jackson because he is of Christian faith. And now, wow, it sounds good because he is Mikhail.

I am very sorry if there are some Americans here. It's not the world's most popular nation now but my son's superheroes come from there, even if they happen to be lazy, drinking, African-American Hancocks. The IPL may not be an art form but it is an entertainment platform. And it has players from all countries sharing dressing rooms and playing for six hours together and for God's sake even if it sounds a little pompous, I have been one of the leading stars of the country for the last 20 years. A Muslim by birth, I am Islamic by faith and supposedly a big star in a Hindu-dominated nation. So that speaks volumes about how easily we accept art without religion. So what happened to our great unifier of differences along the way? What happened to our religions? When did the bells tolling in the temples and the churches, when did the azaans from the minarets and the chants of the Buddhists, when did the Jewish story-telling and the African drums start to play music of such discord? When did the teachings of Mother Art fail in its education to its Child Religion?

It actually happened because you and I believe that peace is the cessation of war, the stopping of terrorism and armed conflict between nations, banning the chemical warfare. I think we have all been wrong. This is the human version of peace. God's version of peace is the beauty you feel when you see a pleasant sight or a picture of misty mountains, it's the emotion you feel when you hear the music of rivers and birds or a Sufi poem, it is the love that you experience when you listen to the stories of saints and believers at the *satsangs* that many of you may be attending. That peace is art. It is art with intense riveting directness that is the key to opening a deep emotional appreciation of each different faith. Allah, the most merciful, the most gracious, did not sanction wars holy or otherwise. *Bhagwan kripalu hai, dayalu hai, mukti dilate hai, mandir aur masjid nahin todwate hai.*

HEMANT CHAWLA